Start A Library Trust

A Library In Every School!

DEBATE GUIDE

A Practical Guide to Building Confident, Critical and Respectful Young Speakers

Reading is Cool - Kusoma ni Poa

TABLE OF CONTENTS

GLOSSARY OF DEBATE TERMS **2**

ABOUT START A LIBRARY TRUST [SAL] **3**

THE PURPOSE OF THE GUIDE **3**

WHAT IS A DEBATE? **4**

a) SAL Inter-School Debate Format at a Glance 4

b) Why Debate Matters 5

PREPARATION TIMELINE (BEFORE DEBATE DAY) **5**

a. Selecting the Motion 6

b. Preparing Learners 6

c. Format and Timing 6

d. Team Composition and Roles 7

e. Judge selection 8

f. Venue and Sitting Arrangement 8

HOW TO CONDUCT A DEBATE **10**

Stage 1: Arrival and preparation 10

Stage 2: Opening 10

Stage 3: Main speeches 10

Stage 4: Rebuttal 11

Stage 5: Judges' scoring 11

Stage 6: Feedback and closing 12

APPENDIX **13**

Appendix 1: How to Build a Strong Argument 13

Appendix 2: Sample Motion Bank 13

Appendix 3: Debate Rules and Expected Behaviour 14

Appendix 4: Recommended Debate-Day Schedule 14

Appendix 5: Judging and Scoring Sheet 11

Appendix 6: English Reading Pledge 13

Appendix 7: Kiswahili Reading Pledge 14

Appendix 8: Inclusion, Safeguarding and Fair Participation 15

GLOSSARY OF DEBATE TERMS

A quick reference for teachers and learners new to debate vocabulary.

Term	Meaning
Motion	The topic or statement being debated, often phrased as "This house believes…".
Proposition	The team arguing in favour of the motion. Also called the Proposers.
Opposition	The team arguing against the motion. Also called the Opposers.
Rebuttal	Directly arguing against a point made by the other team.
Point of Information (POI)	A short question or comment offered to the speaker holding the floor by the opposing team; the speaker may accept or decline it.
Moderator	The person who runs the debate session – introduces speakers, keeps order, and closes the debate.
Judge / Adjudicator	A person who scores the debate and decides the winning team.
Floor	The right to speak; "taking the floor" means it is your turn to speak.
Constructive speech	An early speech that builds a team's own case (as opposed to a rebuttal or reply speech).
Vote of thanks	A short closing statement, given by a speaker from each team, thanking the organizers, judges, and the other team.

ABOUT START A LIBRARY TRUST [SAL]

Start A Library Trust (SAL) was established in 2012 to address these challenges by strengthening foundational learning among children from Early Childhood Development (ECD) through Grade 9 in public primary schools across Kenya. SAL believes that literacy is the foundation for lifelong learning, personal growth and active participation in society. While school libraries are central to our work, they are a tool for improving learning; -not the end goal**.** By creating vibrant reading spaces, equipping teachers with practical literacy approaches and promoting a culture of reading, SAL helps children develop strong literacy skills, life skills and social-emotional competencies. The debate program complements this work by turning reading into opportunities for speaking, listening, reasoning, research and respectful discussion.

THE PURPOSE OF THE GUIDE

This guide supports teachers to plan and run organized, learner-friendly inter-school debate competitions for Grades 4–9. It provides one common process so that participating schools have the defined expectations, roles, timings and scoring.

External curriculum alignment was checked against Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) materials, particularly the Basic Education Curriculum Framework and current curriculum-design resources. The BECF identifies Communication and Collaboration, Critical Thinking and Problem Solving, Creativity and Imagination, Citizenship, Digital Literacy, Learning to Learn and Self-Efficacy as core competencies.

Debates should be treated as a learning activity first and a competition second.

Purpose	**What this means in practice**
Literacy	Learners read, identify information, build vocabulary and use evidence.
Speaking and listening	Learners speak clearly, listen actively and respond to what others say.
Critical thinking	Learners examine claims, compare ideas, identify weaknesses and justify conclusions.
Communication and collaboration	Learners plan together, divide responsibilities and present one team case.
Self-efficacy	Learners practice confidence, preparation and public speaking.
Citizenship and values	Learners disagree respectfully and engage with issues without attacking people.

WHAT IS A DEBATE?

A debate is a structured discussion about a topic, called the motion. Two teams take different positions on the clearly stated motion and a panel of judges decides which team argued its case better.

- **Proposition (or Proposers):** the team that supports the motion.
- **Opposition (or Opposers):** the team that argues against the motion.

Unlike an ordinary discussion, a debate has agreed rules, speaking order, time limits and judging criteria.

Important distinction:

- A debate is not a shouting match.
- A debate is not about attacking another learner.
- A debate is not simply reading a prepared speech.
- A strong debate requires evidence, reasoning, listening and response.

a) SAL Inter-School Debate Format at a Glance

Item	SAL recommended standard
Target grades	Grades 4–9
Teams	2 schools: Proposition and Opposition
Main speakers	6 learners per school: 3 girls and 3 boys where possible
Reserve speakers	2 per school: 1 girl and 1 boy where possible
Patrons	2 teachers per school recommended
Audience	Up to 10 learners per school, where feasible
Judges	3 independent judges, preferably not from participating schools
Moderator	1 teacher/facilitator
Timekeeper	1 learner or teacher
Language	Agreed in advance by both schools; the same language should be used by both teams
Standard speech	4 minutes per main speaker; adjust to age and program needs
Rebuttals	2 rounds; 3 minutes per team per round

Total duration	Approximately 70–90 minutes including opening, scoring and feedback

N/B: Although this guide standardizes the main speaking time at 4 minutes to make the format realistic for Grades 4–9 and easier for teachers to manage, schools may shorten this for classroom practice accordingly.

b) Why Debate Matters

Debate gives learners a structured, safe way to practice skills that reading alone cannot fully build. It matters because it:

- Builds confidence in public speaking and self-expression.
- Strengthens critical thinking, listening, and the ability to construct and defend an argument.
- Motivates wider reading, since learners must research a topic to argue it well – reinforcing the reading culture the library builds.
- Teaches respectful disagreement and teamwork.
- Gives every learner, including quieter ones, a turn to be heard when roles are rotated fairly.

These outcomes fit well with Kenya's Competency-Based Curriculum emphasis on Communication and Collaboration, Critical Thinking and Problem Solving, Creativity and Imagination, Citizenship, Digital Literacy, Learning to Learn and Self-Efficacy. Debate can therefore be used as a practical competency-development activity rather than only as a contest.

PREPARATION TIMELINE (BEFORE DEBATE DAY)

Use this timeline to plan backwards from debate day. Each step is explained in more detail in the sections that follow.

- **2–3 weeks before:** Agree the language of the debate with the opposing school, release the motion/topic to both schools, and point learners to related storybooks or library material for research.
- **1–2 weeks before:** Assign roles by drawing lots, and hold a practice debate so speakers, the timekeeper, and the moderator get comfortable with their roles.
- **1 week before:** Confirm judges, venue, and the sitting arrangement.
- **Debate day:** Learners arrive, rules are read aloud, and the session begins

a. Selecting the Motion

A good motion should:

- be clear and easy to understand
- be age-appropriate
- have two reasonable sides
- connect to learners' lives, curriculum themes or current school/community issues
- allow learners to find evidence in books and other reliable sources
- encourage reasoning rather than memorization
- avoid personal, political, religious or sensitive issues that may expose learners to harm or discrimination
- be broad enough for meaningful arguments but narrow enough to debate within the available time

Because grades 4-9 consist of learners with varying learning capabilities, teachers are encouraged to adjust the difficulty of topic and length of speeches accordingly.

Library link:

Where possible, select motions from themes learners have already explored through story books. This creates a reading-to-speaking pathway: Read → Understand → Research → Discuss → Argue → Reflect.

b. Preparing Learners

Use a simple preparation sequence.

1. Explain the motion and clarify difficult vocabulary.
2. Give both teams the same amount of preparation time.
3. Provide access to relevant library books and approved sources.
4. Ask learners to collect facts, examples, stories, statistics or expert views.
5. Teach learners to record where information came from.
6. Help the team identify 3–5 major arguments instead of collecting too many weak points.
7. Practice each speech aloud.
8. Practice rebuttal using likely arguments from the other team.
9. Conduct a mock debate before competition day.
10. Check pronunciation, timing, confidence, evidence and respectful language.
11. Prepare reserve speakers so they can step in if necessary.

C. Format and Timing

Set timings for each stage in advance and confirm them with all speakers beforehand. Two formats work well:

- **Full interschool debate:** 6 main speakers per side plus rebuttals, typically 60–90 minutes in total (see the sample session plan in the Appendix).
- **Simplified classroom debate:** shorter speeches and fewer speakers, run in 30–40 minutes – useful for junior grades or a first practice round.

d. Team Composition and Roles

<table>
<tr><th>Role</th><th>Main responsibility</th></tr>
<tr><td>Teacher/Patron</td><td>Prepares learners, supports logistics and safeguarding, but does not coach learners during the live debate.</td></tr>
<tr><td>Moderator</td><td>Can be a teacher/patron.
Welcomes participants,
gives opening remarks,
explains the rules,
introduces the motion and teams present,
controls the order of proceedings (invite speakers in order)
ends the debate</td></tr>
<tr><td>Timekeeper</td><td>Usually, a learner or teacher assigned in advance.
Tracks each speaker's time using a watch or timer.
Gives a clear signal when time is almost over, so speakers know to conclude.
Stops time
speakers when ends.
Suggested signals:
.<table><tr><th>Signal</th><th>Meaning</th></tr><tr><td>One clap / bell</td><td>1 minute remaining</td></tr><tr><td>Two claps / bell</td><td>Time is over</td></tr></table></td></tr>
<tr><td>Judges</td><td>3 independent judges, preferably not from participating schools
Score independently,
agree on the results and decide which teams wins
provide constructive feedback to both teams</td></tr>
<tr><td>Captain / Speaker 1</td><td>Defines the motion and presents the team’s case.</td></tr>
<tr><td>Speakers 2–5</td><td>Develop arguments, use evidence, respond to opposing points and strengthen the team case.</td></tr>
<tr><td>Speaker 6</td><td>One learner from each team makes a final argument directly to the judges, summarizes the team's case, and gives closing remarks. This should ideally be the strongest persuader on the team.</td></tr>
<tr><td>Audience</td><td>Listens respectfully, learns from both teams and participates only when invited.</td></tr>
</table>

Reserve speakers	Remain prepared to replace a speaker if the school has an agreed reason for substitution.

e. Judge selection

The judges are responsible for fairly assessing all participating schools, determining the winning teams in each debate session, and identifying the Best Debater. Judges should remain impartial, consistent and objective throughout the competition.

When selecting judges, look for:

- Neutrality – not a teacher, parent, or relative of either competing school, and with no prior knowledge of the specific motion that could create bias.
- Subject familiarity – comfortable with the motion's topic area, or willing to read the motion brief in advance so they can follow the arguments.
- Listening and note-taking ability – able to track multiple speakers' points across a 60–90-minute session without losing the thread.
- Fair-mindedness – willing to score based on how well a team argued, not which side of the motion/ school the judge personally agrees with.
- Comfort giving feedback to children – able to deliver both praise and constructive criticism in an encouraging, age-appropriate way.
- Punctuality and availability – able to commit to the full session, including the pre-debate briefing and post-debate scoring discussion.

Suggested sources for judges:

- Teachers or teacher-librarians not affiliated with either participating school
- School administrators (deputy head, head teacher) not involved in coaching either team
- SAL reading ambassadors
- Retired teachers or local literacy volunteers
- Older students (Grade 8–9) as an optional "junior judge" panel alongside adult judges, for peer-feedback value

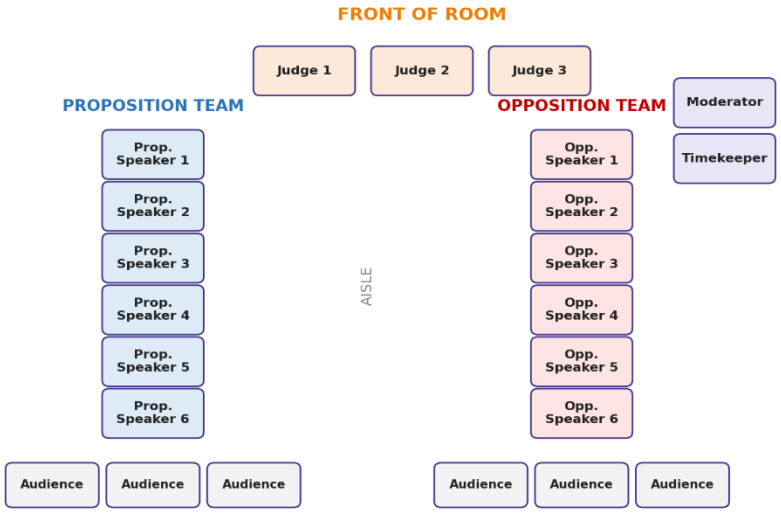
f. Venue and Sitting Arrangement

Before learners arrive, check that:

- the room is large enough for both teams and the audience
- the motion is displayed clearly
- teams can see the moderator and timekeeper
- judges can see and hear both teams
- the timekeeper has a visible clock or timer
- there is safe and accessible movement to the speaking area

- learners with disabilities or additional needs can participate comfortable

Recommended arrangement: each team sits in speaking order, nearest the front. Judges sit at the front facing both teams.
The moderator and timekeeper sit to one side with a clear view of both teams. The audience sits behind or beside the teams.



Teacher Checklist during debate preparation

- ☐ Motion is clear, age-appropriate and balanced.
- ☐ Both schools received the motion at the same time.
- ☐ Both teams have access to comparable preparation resources.
- ☐ Debate language has been agreed.
- ☐ Speakers and reserve speakers are confirmed.
- ☐ Moderator, judges and timekeeper are confirmed.
- ☐ Judges have received the rubric and understand the criteria.
- ☐ Venue and sitting arrangement are ready.
- ☐ Visible timer is available.
- ☐ Rules and timings are displayed.
- ☐ Safeguarding and inclusion needs have been considered.
- ☐ Learners have practiced speeches and rebuttals.
- ☐ Sources have been checked for basic reliability.
- ☐ Judging sheets, pens and attendance records are ready.
- ☐ Feedback and reflection time has been protected.

HOW TO CONDUCT A DEBATE

Stage 1: Arrival and preparation

Check attendance, team lists, reserves, judges, timing device, judging sheets and seating.

Stage 2: Opening

- The moderator welcomes everyone.
- The national anthem is sang aloud followed by reciting of the reading pledge.
- The moderator introduces the motion and teams.
- The moderator introduces judges and the timekeeper.
- The rules and speaking times are read aloud.
- The moderator confirms which team is Proposition and which is Opposition.

Stage 3: Main speeches

Speaker	Time	Main task
Proposition 1	4 min	Define the motion, state the team position and give key arguments.
Opposition 1	4 min	State the opposition position, respond to the first case and present key counter-arguments.
Proposition 2	4 min	Develop a new argument and rebut relevant opposition points.
Opposition 2	4 min	Develop a new argument and rebut relevant proposition points.
Proposition 3	4 min	Strengthen the case with evidence and respond to opposition.
Opposition 3	4 min	Strengthen the case with evidence and respond to proposition.
Proposition 4	4 min	Continue the case and address major weaknesses identified.
Opposition 4	4 min	Continue the case and address major weaknesses identified.
Proposition 5	4 min	Respond to key opposition arguments and consolidate the case.
Opposition 5	4 min	Respond to key proposition arguments and consolidate the case.
Proposition 6	4 min	Final case summary and strongest closing argument.
Opposition 6	4 min	Final case summary and strongest closing argument.

For younger or less experienced learners, use 2–3-minute speeches and fewer speakers during practice sessions.

Stage 4: Rebuttal

Rebuttal is the part of the debate where a speaker directly responds/argues to a point made by the other team. It is not a second chance to introduce unrelated new arguments.

Rules may include a short recess (5 minutes) for both teams to prepare their rebuttals.

- **1st Rebuttal:** the opposing team begins, followed by the proposing team. Both teams defend their own arguments and challenge the other team's arguments, without adding new information (3–5 minutes each).
- **2nd Rebuttal:** each team gives closing statements, with the proposing team speaking last (3–5 minutes each).

Useful sentence starters when rebutting:

- The other team argued that…
- We understand their point, but…
- This argument is not convincing because…
- The evidence we found shows…
- Even if that is true, it does not prove that…
- For this reason, our position remains…

Speakers should use the four-step rebuttal:

- Identify the point: name or clearly describe the opponent's argument.
- Show understanding: briefly explain what the opponent said.
- Challenge it: explain why the point is weak, incomplete or incorrect.
- Support your response: give evidence, an example or reasoning, then link back to your team's position.

Stage 5: Judges' scoring

Judges score independently first. They then compare scores, resolve any calculation issues and agree on the result.

Time penalties should be simple and announced before the debate. For example, a speaker who exceeds the limit by more than 30 seconds may lose 1 mark, with a maximum deduction agreed in advance. Do not change the penalty after the debate has started.

Judges are expected to:

- Remain neutral and impartial throughout the competition.
- Give every school an equal opportunity to demonstrate its abilities.
- Avoid coaching, prompting or influencing debaters during a session.
- Score independently and honestly.
- Base decisions on performance, not reputation, school identity or personal relationships.
- Maintain confidentiality regarding scores and deliberations.
- Provide constructive feedback where requested.
- Treat all learners, teachers and fellow judges with professionalism and respect.

Recommended scoring principle: judges should use the full range of marks. A learner does not receive a high score simply for speaking loudly or confidently; evidence, reasoning, listening and response are equally important.

Stage 6: Feedback and closing

- The judges announce the result.
- The judges give strengths first, followed by practical areas for improvement.
- Feedback is directed to teams, not personal attacks on individual learners.
- One learner from each team gives a vote of thanks.
- The moderator closes the session.
- Teams may shake hands or offer another culturally appropriate gesture of sportsmanship

Feedback and Reflection led by the Teacher. Immediately after the debate, ask your learners:

- ❖ What was our strongest argument?
- ❖ Which opposing argument was hardest to answer?
- ❖ Did we use evidence effectively?
- ❖ Did we listen to the other team?
- ❖ Did every speaker contribute?
- ❖ Did we stay within time?
- ❖ What will we change in our next debate?

N/B: Teacher reflection should also consider reading outcomes: Did learners read relevant books? Did they use new vocabulary? Could they identify evidence? Did they understand what they read well enough to use it in an argument?

APPENDIX

Appendix 1: How to Build a Strong Argument

Teach learners to use this simple structure:

Part	Question	Example
Claim	What are we saying?	School libraries improve reading.
Reason	Why do we believe it?	Learners get more opportunities to practice reading.
Evidence	What supports our claim?	Our library records show regular reading sessions and wider book access.
Explanation	How does the evidence prove the point?	More practice and access help learners read more often.
Link	How does this support the motion?	Therefore, schools should invest in libraries.

Remind learners: evidence must be relevant and credible. They should say where information came from rather than presenting every statement as fact.

Appendix 2: Sample Motion Bank

Use these as a starting point, and adapt them to storybooks currently available in your school library.

Examples of suitable motions:

- Schools should give learners more time to read for pleasure.
- Every school should have a school garden.
- Homework should be reduced in primary school.
- Children should have limited screen time on school days.
- School libraries are more important than computer labs for young learners.

Appendix 3: Debate Rules and Expected Behaviour

Learners should:

- speak one at a time
- listen when others are speaking
- address ideas, not people
- use respectful language
- support important claims with evidence or examples
- paraphrase an opponent's point before rebutting it
- remain within the time limit
- follow the moderator's instructions
- accept the judges' decision respectfully
- show good sportsmanship.

Learners should not:

- shout, insult, mock or threaten another learner
- interrupt deliberately
- laugh at mistakes
- make discriminatory or humiliating comments
- fabricate evidence or sources
- read a speech without engaging with the debate
- introduce a completely new argument during final rebuttal
- receive coaching from teachers during their speech.

Appendix 4: Recommended Debate-Day Schedule

Time	Activity	Lead
5 min	Arrival, registration and seating	Patrons
5 min	Welcome and introduction	Moderator
5 min	Introduce teams, judges and timekeeper; read rules	Moderator
48 min	12 main speeches × 4 minutes	Speakers / Timekeeper
6 min	Rebuttal Round 1: 3 min per team	Audience
6 min	Rebuttal Round 2: 3 min per team	Audience
5 min	Judges finalize scores	Judges
5 –10 min	Results and feedback	Judges / Moderator
5 mins	Reflection	Moderator
5 min	Vote of thanks and closing	Moderator / Learners

Total: approximately 90 minutes. For a shorter school-based debate, reduce speech times and/or number of speakers.

Appendix 5: Judging and Scoring Sheet

Motion: _____

Proposing School: _____

Opposing School: _____

Judge: _____ Venue: _____

Date: _____

Criterion	Interpretation	Proposition	Opposition
Understanding of motion	Accurate interpretation and clear position.	_____/10	_____/10
Argument and reasoning	Logical, relevant and well-organized arguments.	_____/15	_____/15
Evidence and examples	Relevant, credible and clearly explained support.	_____/10	_____/10
Rebuttal and response	Directly addresses opposing points and explains why they are weak.	_____/15	_____/15
Delivery and communication	Clear voice, pace, pronunciation, eye contact and confidence.	_____/10	_____/10
Listening and engagement	Shows awareness of what the other team has said.	_____/10	_____/10
Teamwork and organization	Speakers build one coherent team case and share roles effectively.	_____/10	_____/10
Respect and discipline	Professional conduct, turn-taking and respectful language.	_____/5	_____/5
Time management	Keeps within the agreed speaking time.	_____/5	_____/5
Closing and synthesis	Summarizes the strongest points and reinforces the team position.	_____/10	_____/10
TOTAL		_____**/100**	_____**/100**

Result: ☐ Proposition wins ☐ Opposition wins ☐ Tie / further review

Three strengths observed:

Proposition:	**Opposition:**
1)	1)
2)	2)
3)	3)

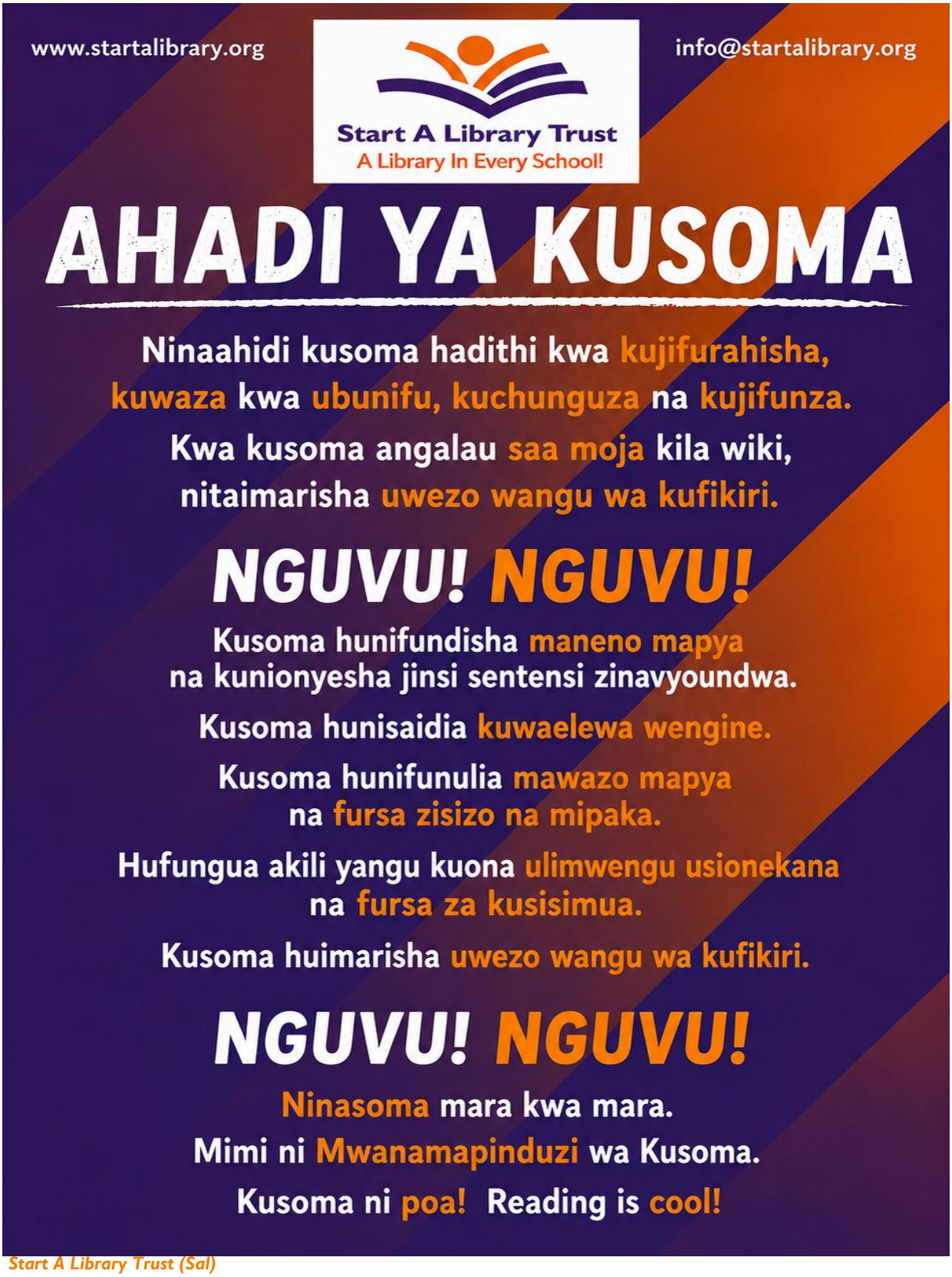
One priority for improvement

Proposition:	**Opposition:**

Appendix 6: English Reading Pledge



Appendix 7: Kiswahili Reading Pledge



Appendix 8: Inclusion, Safeguarding and Fair Participation

- Do not select speakers only on the basis of confidence; use debate to build confidence.
- Provide reasonable adjustments for learners with disabilities or communication needs.
- Allow learners who are less confident to begin with research, timekeeping, question preparation or shorter practice speeches.
- Do not use sensitive personal experiences as debate material without appropriate safeguarding consideration.
- Do not permit humiliating, discriminatory or threatening comments.
- Ensure teachers and judges model respectful disagreement.
- Have a clear process for addressing a safeguarding concern or serious misconduct.
- Protect learners' privacy when taking photographs, recordings or sharing results.

